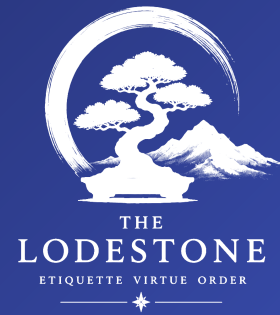


A PARENT'S GUIDE

Speech & Language

When words are slow to come, early, playful help makes a real difference.



A speech delay means a child's talking is developing more slowly than expected, whether that's how clearly they say sounds, or how they understand and use words. It is common, and it isn't a sign of low intelligence. The early years are when language grows fastest, so gentle, playful support now is one of the most powerful things you can do, there's rarely a downside to starting early.

Signs you might recognise

- ✓ Says far fewer words than other children their age
- ✓ Is hard to understand, even for close family
- ✓ Struggles to put words together into sentences
- ✓ Gets frustrated, points or cries when not understood
- ✓ Leaves out sounds, or finds some sounds hard
- ✓ Understands more than they can say

What you can do at home

- **Narrate your day.** Talk through what you're doing in simple words. Bathing your child in language gives them more to copy.
- **Get face to face, then wait.** Come down to their level, follow what they're looking at, and pause, give them time to have a go.
- **Expand, don't correct.** If your child says 'car', reply warmly: 'yes, a fast red car!' Model the fuller version instead of saying 'wrong'.
- **Offer choices to spark words.** 'Milk or water?' gently invites your child to use a word rather than just point.
- **Read and play every day.** Point and name, make animal sounds, use puppets, anything that makes communicating fun and rewarding.

- **Keep screens low for under-3s.** Language grows through back-and-forth interaction far more than from a screen.

Make talking joyful, never a test. Avoid drilling 'say this' and follow the fun instead.

When it's worth seeking support

Consider reaching out if, over time, you notice:

- › Far fewer words than other children the same age
- › Still very hard to understand by around age three
- › Real frustration at not being understood
- › Any worry, it's always worth checking early rather than waiting

How The Lodestone Centre can help

We build speech and language the way young children learn best, through play, in short, joyful sessions, and we coach you with simple things to do at home so progress carries over. An optional screening shows what to target first.

Programs that often help: Say Play (Speech), Screening, SEL Program, Lodestone Evo, Reading & Literacy Program.

Free 15-minute call · WhatsApp 012-212 7743 · thelodestonesolution.com

This guide is for general information and to support parents. The Lodestone Centre provides educational support, screening and programs; it is not a substitute for formal schooling or a clinical diagnosis. If you have concerns about your child's development, a screening or a chat with our team is a good next step.